

Recession throws spaceflight plans for a toss

NEWS

In a major setback to the human spaceflight program, NASA representatives of the Human Spaceflight Review Committee meeting in Washington DC, announced that all plans for spaceflight beyond low earth orbit were temporarily on hold. The budget for the next five years, till 2014 is apparently on hold. This is a considerable setback for the Saturn V program, which is the rocket of choice for future space missions. Of course, this also puts back the plans for NASA's circa 2020s plans for another series of moon landings, with elaborate permanent habitation plans. All the space agencies are pooling resources for some time, to pull through, because of the already colossal costs of space travel.

tech art: pixel art



Image Credit: Helm

Pixel art is the process of drawing pixel by pixel. This is a painstaking and long process, and there are a number of approaches. Any form of digital painting that calculates pixels, or does not give absolute pixel-level control to the artist is not considered to be pixel art. The early versions of pixel art used software that allowed artists to hand draw individual pixels only. Pixel art is usually very small in terms of dimensions, but there are large and extremely detailed pixel art web sites around. For more, head over to <http://www.pixeljoint.com>.

The Pale Blue Dot

HISTORY

Almost everyone has seen the image known as the Blue Marble, which was one of the first images taken of earth from outer space. A lesser known picture, is the "Pale blue dot". Voyager 1, the man made object that has ventured most into space, turned around to look back just as it was leaving the outer limits of the Solar System. This was because Carl Sagan, the sci-Fi author of Contact, asked NASA to photograph the planet from 3.7 billion miles away. The purpose of this exercise was to show mankind's humble place in the universe, and the resulting photograph had a small blue dot basking in the rays of the sun. Technically, it was half a dot as the planet was so small from so far away that it registered only half a pixel on Voyager's sensor.



For those who came in late

Muddled by so many terms used in the mag? Here's your short guide to the tech lingo

TLD: Top Level Domains, such as .com, .net, .org etc, maintained and managed by the Internet Corporation for Assigned Names and Numbers.

Rootkit: Rootkits are processes in the system that hide the presence of trojans, worms, or other exploits from the user.

AES: The advanced encryption standard, a secure algorithm used for encrypting data worldwide.

E3: Electronic Entertainment Expo, an annual convention for the gaming industry.

Semantic Web: Ideally an intelligent web, that responds to our needs, practically a layer of information processing and packaging between the reader and the content.